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UAE Presidential Court

## PRESIDENT MEETS RULER OF FUJAIRAH

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan yesterday received His Highness Sheikh Hamad Bin Mohammed Al Sharqi, Supreme Council Member and Ruler of Fujairah. During the meeting, Their Highnesses exchanged cordial greetings and discussed various topics of importance to the nation and its citizens, reaffirming the UAE's steadfast commitment to placing them at the heart of its current and future developmental plans and objectives.

## UAE banks extend profit growth

Largest lenders  
expand loans and  
deposits in H1 2026

**DUBAI**  
BY JUSTIN VARGHESE  
Your Money Editor

The UAE's banking sector delivered another strong set of first-half earnings, with the country's largest lenders reporting higher profits, expanding loan books and continued deposit inflows as economic activity remained resilient.

Emirates NBD posted a record pre-tax profit of Dh16.2

billion after expanding its loan book by Dh114 billion and completing the acquisition of RBL Bank, while First Abu Dhabi Bank reported net profit of Dh10.73 billion, supported by higher lending, stronger net interest income and improving asset quality.

### Continuous growth

Abu Dhabi Commercial Bank recorded its 20th consecutive quarter of profit growth, with H1 profit before tax rising 28 per cent to a record Dh7.61 billion as loans, deposits and fee income increased.

Emirates Islamic also re-

ported double-digit operating profit growth, driven by financing expansion and higher customer deposits.

Commercial Bank of Dubai, RAKBank and United Arab Bank all reported higher profits, backed by loan growth, stronger non-interest income and healthier balance sheets.

Asset quality improved across most lenders, with non-performing loan ratios declining, while capital and liquidity buffers remained comfortably above regulatory requirements, positioning banks to support further lending in the second half of 2026.

SEE ALSO P-1

# TRUMP THREATENS HOUTHIS WITH 'MAJOR PUNISHMENT'

Iran-backed group targets Saudi-owned vessel

**DUBAI**

Gulf News Report

US President Donald Trump yesterday threatened Yemen's Houthi rebels with "major military punishment" after they launched missile and drone strikes on oil tankers in the Red Sea.

"The US will hold Iran responsible, in that the Houthis are a Surrogate and/or Proxy of Iran, and major military punishment will be inflicted upon Iran and, of course, the Houthis themselves" should the rebels launch further attacks, Trump said on his Truth Social network.

### Two tankers struck

Earlier, Yemen's Iran-backed Houthi rebels said they attacked two Saudi oil tankers, the Encelia and the Layla, in the Red Sea yesterday, potentially opening a new front as the US military conducted a 12th night of strikes against Iran. The state-run Saudi Press Agency reported an attack set the Encelia ablaze overnight in the Red Sea. It did not mention the Layla.

As the rhetoric escalated, so

## SAUDI ARABIA, US SIGN NUCLEAR DEAL

Saudi Arabia and the United States have signed a landmark nuclear cooperation agreement that marks a major step in the Kingdom's plans to develop civilian nuclear energy and diversify its economy beyond oil.

The agreement, known as a 123 Agreement, establishes the legal framework that allows the United States to share civilian nuclear technology, expertise and equipment with Saudi Arabia. It also opens the door for American companies to participate in developing the Kingdom's nuclear energy sector, potentially creating billions of dollars in investment opportunities over the coming decades.

—Ashfaq Ahmed, Managing Editor

did the economic fallout. Brent crude was trading at \$100.79 per barrel, up more than 7 per cent during yesterday's trading session.

### Iranian strikes continue

Iran, meanwhile, continued its aggression against Gulf states by targeting energy infrastructure and desalination plants providing drinking water.

Jordan said its military had intercepted three missiles early yesterday, with a fourth falling in an empty area, while six drones were intercepted Wednesday night. Bahrain's Interior Ministry posted on X that sirens had

sounded and urged the public to remain calm and head to a safe area. Kuwait's military said that drones had attacked its border crossing with Iraq, causing damage but no casualties. That attack may have been in response to the US strike on the Iran-Iraq border crossing.

### UAE slams attacks

The UAE has condemned in the strongest terms the renewed hostile attacks by Iran targeting Bahrain, Kuwait and Jordan with missiles and drones. The UAE also condemned Houthi attacks targeting Saudi vessels.

SEE ALSO P6, 7

**FRIDAY**

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